MASTER GUIDE

FlowKeys

The mechanical keyboard sound you love.
On the computer you already own.

macOS

Windows

v1.1.0 — Free & Open Source

THE PROBLEM

Mechanical keyboards are incredible. Their price tags aren't.

There's something deeply satisfying about a mechanical keyboard. The crisp click on every keypress. The tactile feedback under your fingers. It transforms typing from a chore into something you actually enjoy.

But that experience comes at a cost.

Entry-level mechanical keyboard	$60 – $80
Mid-range (Cherry MX, hot-swap)	$100 – $180
Premium (wireless, RGB, aluminum)	$180 – $300
Custom build (enthusiast-grade)	$300 – $800+

What if you didn't have to choose?

Mechanical Keyboard

$80 – $300+

Plus desk space. Plus cable clutter.

FlowKeys

Free

Same sound. Zero cost. Zero clutter.

THE SOLUTION

Every keypress.
A satisfying click.

FlowKeys is a lightweight app that runs quietly in the background. Every time you press a key, it plays a crisp, realistic mechanical keyboard sound through your speakers or headphones.

No external hardware. No complicated setup. No subscription. Works on both Mac and Windows.

Two sounds. Your choice.

Mechanical

The classic Cherry MX blue click. Sharp, crisp, unmistakable. The sound you hear in every coding video and ASMR typing session.

Soft

A quieter, gentler tactile tap. Subtle enough for shared spaces, coffee shops, or late-night sessions.

Switch between them instantly with a keyboard shortcut.

Built to disappear.

Auto-start

Starts when your computer starts. No manual launching, no dock icon, no menu bar clutter.

Near-zero latency

Sounds are pre-loaded into memory. ~12ms response time. The click arrives the instant your finger hits the key.

Lightweight

Minimal CPU and memory. No noticeable impact on battery life or performance.

Mac Setup Guide

One Terminal command. Grant one permission. About 5 minutes.

1 Open Terminal

Press `Cmd + Space` to open Spotlight. Type **Terminal** and press **Enter**.

2 Paste the install command

Copy and paste this entire line into Terminal, then press **Enter**:

```
/bin/bash -c "$(curl -fsSL
https://raw.githubusercontent.com/rhalder90/FlowKeys/main/install-remote.sh)"
```

The installer downloads FlowKeys, installs dependencies, and sets up auto-start. Takes about 30 seconds.

3 Grant Accessibility permission

The installer opens System Settings automatically. You need to add two items:

- Click the **+** button
- Press `Cmd + Shift + G` to open "Go to folder"
- Type the **exact path shown by the installer** and press Enter
- Click **Open** and make sure the toggle is **ON**
- Click **+** again → go to Applications → Utilities → **Terminal** → Open → toggle **ON**

✓ Done. Start typing.

FlowKeys auto-starts on every login. Nothing to remember.

> **Why the path?** macOS tracks Accessibility permissions by the actual binary. The installer detects the correct Python binary for your system. If permission breaks after a Python update, run: `python3 ~/FlowKeys/main.py --fix-permissions`

UNINSTALL MAC

Open Terminal and paste:

```
/bin/bash -c "$(curl -fsSL
https://raw.githubusercontent.com/rhalder90/FlowKeys/main/uninstall-remote.sh)"
```

Windows Setup Guide

Download. Double-click. Done. Under 2 minutes.

1 Download FlowKeys.exe

Go to **github.com/rhalder90/FlowKeys/releases** and download **FlowKeys.exe**. That's the entire app — one file, nothing to install.

2 Double-click FlowKeys.exe

Windows may show a blue warning: **"Windows protected your PC"**. This is normal for unsigned apps downloaded from the internet.

- Click **More info**
- Click **Run anyway**

This only happens the first time.

3 No permissions needed

Unlike macOS, Windows lets FlowKeys hear your keystrokes without any extra setup. Just start typing.

✓ Done. Start typing.

You'll hear a mechanical click on every keypress immediately.

> **SmartScreen warning:** Windows shows this for any unsigned app downloaded from the internet. FlowKeys is free, open source, and safe. Click **More info** → **Run anyway**.

> **Auto-start on login:** Run `FlowKeys.exe --enable-autostart` once. After that, FlowKeys starts automatically every time you turn on your PC. To remove: `FlowKeys.exe --disable-autostart`

UNINSTALL WINDOWS

1. If you enabled auto-start, run `FlowKeys.exe --disable-autostart` first.
2. Delete **FlowKeys.exe**. That's it. No registry entries, no hidden files.

KEYBOARD SHORTCUTS

Two shortcuts. Both platforms.

MAC	WINDOWS	ACTION
`Cmd + Ctrl + K`	`Win + Ctrl + K`	Toggle sound on/off
`Cmd + Ctrl + S`	`Win + Ctrl + S`	Switch between mechanical and soft

FREQUENTLY ASKED QUESTIONS

Everything you need to know.

What is FlowKeys?

A tiny free app that plays a mechanical keyboard click sound every time you press a key. Works on Mac and Windows.

Is it free?

Yes. Free and open source (MIT license). No ads, no subscriptions, no hidden costs.

Does it work on Mac?

Yes. Run the one-line installer in Terminal. Requires Python 3 (most Macs have it already).

Does it work on Windows?

Yes. Download **FlowKeys.exe** from the GitHub Releases page. No installation, no Python, no setup needed.

Do I need to install Python?

Mac: Python 3 is required. Most Macs have it already. The installer will tell you if it's missing.
Windows: No. The .exe bundles everything. Just download and run.

Does it start automatically when I restart?

Mac: Yes, automatically. The installer sets this up.
Windows: Run `FlowKeys.exe --enable-autostart` once. After that, it starts on every login.

How do I stop it?

Press `Ctrl+C` in the terminal window, or close the window. On Windows, you can also use Task Manager.

How do I switch between mechanical and soft sounds?

Press `Cmd+Ctrl+S` on Mac or `Win+Ctrl+S` on Windows.

Why does Mac need Accessibility permission but Windows doesn't?

macOS requires explicit permission for any app that monitors keyboard input. Windows allows keyboard hooks without special permissions. This is a difference in how each operating system handles security.

Can I use it on both Mac and Windows?

Yes. The same codebase runs on both. Mac uses the Terminal installer, Windows uses the .exe.

FAQ (CONTINUED)

Will my antivirus flag it? (Windows)

Some antivirus programs may flag keyboard hooks as suspicious. This is because FlowKeys listens to your keypresses to play sounds. Add FlowKeys as an exception if your antivirus blocks it. FlowKeys is open source — you can verify the code yourself.

Why does Windows say "Windows protected your PC"?

This is Windows SmartScreen. It shows this for any unsigned .exe downloaded from the internet. Click **More info** → **Run anyway**. This is a one-time warning.

Where are the log files?

Mac: `~/Library/Logs/FlowKeys/flowkeys.log`
Windows: `%LOCALAPPDATA%\FlowKeys\Logs\flowkeys.log`

TROUBLESHOOTING — MAC

Something not working on Mac?

No sound when I type

This is almost always the Accessibility permission. Go to **System Settings → Privacy & Security → Accessibility** and make sure both the Python binary and Terminal are listed and toggled ON. You can also run: `python3 ~/FlowKeys/main.py --fix-permissions`

FlowKeys doesn't start after reboot

Run `launchctl list | grep flowkeys` in Terminal. If nothing shows up, re-run the install command.

"FlowKeys is already running"

Another instance is active. Run in Terminal:

```
pkill -9 -f "FlowKeys" && rm -f ~/.flowkeys.pid
```

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macOS blocks install.command

Use the one-line Terminal installer instead — it bypasses Gatekeeper completely.

Python or dependency errors

Check your Python version: `python3 --version`. Reinstall dependencies: `pip3 install pynput pygame-ce`

TROUBLESHOOTING — WINDOWS

Something not working on Windows?

No sound when I type

Make sure your volume is not muted. Some antivirus software may block keyboard hooks — add FlowKeys as an exception. Try running as Administrator (right-click → Run as administrator).

"FlowKeys is already running"

Open Task Manager → find FlowKeys → End task. Then run FlowKeys.exe again.

Sound is delayed

Close audio-heavy apps (video calls, music production software). FlowKeys uses ~12ms latency — any delay is usually caused by system audio contention.

Keyboard shortcuts don't work in admin apps

If you run an app as Administrator, FlowKeys can't detect keypresses in that app unless FlowKeys is also running as Administrator. This is a Windows security feature.

STILL STUCK?

write.rhalder90@gmail.com

Free & open source • github.com/rhalder90/FlowKeys

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